Why this happened is unclear and needs further investigation, but the Congress, at least in this final lap of the poll, seemed to have taken its foot off the accelerator.

Where the BJP Scored: Campaign Gaps and Ground Game

It is useful to see these digital trends in tandem with the offline campaigning patterns of Narendra Modi and Rahul Gandhi. Modi addressed 142 rallies during the 2019 campaign, travelling a cumulative 1,33,349 km, as recorded by the *Times of India*'s detailed rally-by-rally campaign tracker. Rahul Gandhi, the challenger, in contrast, addressed a fewer number of rallies (115), travelling less than the incumbent (1,23,466 km).[60] It is striking that, in the first half of the campaign, Gandhi clocked up more rallies and distance mileage than Modi on the campaign tracker. In the last month, however, while Modi went all-out on rallies and travel, Rahul fell behind.

Even more revealing is where both leaders chose to focus their energies. In UP, which accounts for the most Lok Sabha seats (eighty) and which the BJP swept, Modi addressed thirty-one rallies (13,455 km) compared to Gandhi's twelve (6,564 km). We saw similar trends in most big battleground states, where the number of Modi rallies far outstripped those by Gandhi: West Bengal (Modi: seventeen, Gandhi: three), Bihar (Modi: nine, Gandhi: five), Maharashtra (Modi: nine, Gandhi: four), Odisha (Modi: eight, Gandhi: two). While rally numbers are but one indicator in a complex matrix of factors, they are indicative of a political party's ground-game emphasis.

While Modi seemed to be concentrating on difficult states where the BJP was facing challenges (like UP, with the BSP–SP alliance, or new catchment areas for the party like West Bengal and Odisha), the rally pattern shows that Gandhi travelled more than Modi to states where the Congress already seemed strong: Kerala, Karnataka, Punjab, Rajasthan (after the assembly elections in December). As Congress leader Jairam Ramesh says, 'I don't think we should make the mistake of saying that BJP was winning only because of social media. They are able to supplement social media with door-to-door